

Slimy blanket

While it sleeps, a steephead parrotfish produces slime from its skin to build up a cocoon around it. This shield takes around an hour to make, and protects the fish from predators and also serves as a barrier to infectious parasites.



Diversity hot spot

The stunning coral reefs between the Philippines and Papua New Guinea have the highest diversity of marine animals in the world. Known as the Coral Triangle, this region covers 2¼ million sq miles (6 million sq km) and is also home to 75 percent of all coral species.



The Philippines

The warm, shallow waters around the Philippines represent the northernmost reach of the Coral Triangle, a region known for its diverse coral reefs and fish species.

White-sand islands

Many tiny islands in the western Pacific are surrounded by white beaches made of sand produced by the poop of thousands of coral-eating parrotfish.

Papua New Guinea

Islands off the coast of this country have some of the richest reefs anywhere on Earth.

AUSTRALASIA

SOLOMON ISLANDS

Indo-Pacific beauty

The steephead parrotfish is scattered throughout parts of the Indian Ocean to the Pacific islands of Polynesia. This species' showy colors help them recognize their own kind in crowded, reef-dwelling communities. It also uses its beak to break the rocky coral, digesting its softer flesh and pooping the rocky parts as white sand.

Northwest Australia

Coral reefs on the narrow continental shelf around this region extend the range of Indo-Pacific fish, such as the steephead parrotfish, into the fringes of the Indian Ocean.

Head hump

Only males of the steephead parrotfish develop a head hump, but all youngsters have the potential to do so. This is because younger females can change their sex and turn into males.

PARROTFISH HAVE A SET OF TEETH IN THEIR THROAT TO GRIND DOWN ROCKY CORAL



INDIAN OCEAN